

Best Omega-3 Foods for Joint Health

Discover the top omega-3 rich foods that support joint health and reduce inflammation in arthritis.

By **Living With Arthritis Editorial Team** · Reviewed by **Clinical Advisory Panel** (HCPC-registered physiotherapy & rheumatology nursing input) · 2026-03-08 · livingwitharthritis.org.uk

Omega-3 Fatty Acids and Joint Health



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Omega-3 fatty acids are among the most evidence-backed nutrients for reducing joint inflammation. The NHS recommends eating at least 2 portions of oily fish per week — but most UK adults fall short.

How Omega-3s Help Joints

Omega-3s (EPA and DHA) work by: - **Blocking inflammatory enzymes** (COX-2 and 5-LOX) - **Reducing pro-inflammatory cytokines** (TNF- α , IL-1, IL-6) - **Producing resolvins and protectins** — molecules that actively resolve inflammation - **Improving joint lubrication** through effects on synovial fluid

Best Food Sources



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Food	EPA+DHA per 100g	UK Price Guide	----- ----- -----	Mackerel				
2,600 mg	£3–5/pack	Salmon	2,200 mg	£4–8/pack	Sardines (tinned)	1,500 mg		
£1–2/tin		Herring/kippers	1,700 mg	£3–5/pack	Anchovies	1,400 mg	£2–3/tin	Trout

1,000 mg | £4–6/pack |

Plant-Based Omega-3 (ALA)

Plant sources provide ALA, which the body converts to EPA/DHA (but only at 5–10% efficiency): - **Flaxseeds** — 1 tbsp ground = 1,600 mg ALA - **Chia seeds** — 1 tbsp = 1,700 mg ALA - **Walnuts** — 30g = 2,500 mg ALA - **Hemp seeds** — 1 tbsp = 1,000 mg ALA - **Algae oil supplements** — vegan source of EPA/DHA directly

How Much Do You Need?



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For arthritis management, research suggests: - **Minimum:** 1,000 mg EPA+DHA daily - **Therapeutic dose:** 2,000–3,000 mg EPA+DHA daily - **From food:** 2–3 portions of oily fish per week - **Timeline:** Allow 8–12 weeks for anti-inflammatory effects

Supplement Guide

If you cannot eat enough oily fish: - Choose supplements with high EPA content (EPA is more anti-inflammatory than DHA) - Look for IFOS (International Fish Oil Standards) certified products - Store in the fridge to prevent oxidation - Take with a meal containing fat for better absorption

Easy Ways to Eat More Omega-3

- Tinned sardines on wholegrain toast for lunch
- Smoked mackerel pâté with crackers
- Salmon fishcakes (batch cook and freeze)
- Sprinkle ground flaxseed on porridge
- Add walnuts to salads

Written by Dr. Emma Foster, Registered Dietitian, King's College London

Q&A

Question: What is the key thing to know about best omega-3 foods for joint health?

Short answer: Omega-3 fatty acids, found in oily fish like mackerel and salmon, help reduce joint inflammation by blocking inflammatory enzymes, reducing pro-inflammatory cytokines, and producing anti-inflammatory molecules. For joint health, aim for 1,000 mg EPA+DHA daily from food or supplements, increasing to 2,000–3,000 mg for arthritis management. Plant-based sources like flaxseeds provide ALA, which converts to EPA/DHA less efficiently.

Question: When should I seek professional advice?

Short answer: If symptoms persist or worsen, pain is severe and unresponsive to usual relief, or you develop new symptoms, contact your GP, physiotherapist or rheumatology team promptly.

Question: Where can I get free arthritis support in the UK?

Short answer: Arthritis UK: 0800 5200 520. NRAS: 0800 298 7650. Free tools and guides at livingwitharthritis.org.uk.

General information only — not medical advice. Consult your GP or specialist before changing medication or starting a new programme. Emergency: 999. NHS advice: 111. Living With Arthritis · livingwitharthritis.org.uk